missing out on seeing my children grow up, seemed worthwhile. Their father had finally become part of a World Cup-winning team, something he had strived for all his life.

The party went on into the early hours of the morning. With loud music blaring out, the doors to all the players' rooms were wide open. Anyone could come in and have a drink and celebrate. In one memorable moment Virat, Bhajji and Yuvi went down on their knees and sang '*Tujme rabh dikhta hai yaara mai kya karu*' (What to do, my friend, in you we see God himself!) from the film *Rab Ne Bana Di Jodi* and managed to seriously embarrass me.

At around 3 a.m., we were called to go up and join in a special celebration put together by the team management. A couple of hours later, I finally went back to my room to get some sleep. This time I bolted my door, knowing that otherwise some of my team-mates were bound to crash in, as the party was still in full swing.

At 7 a.m. I heard Zaheer Khan and Ashish Nehra banging on my door, wanting to share a drink. I just smiled to myself and went back to sleep.

A happy homecoming

The day after the final went by in a rush. After fulfilling the ICC's requirements of a few photo shoots and meeting our president, Mrs Pratibha Patil, at Raj Bhavan, I finally made it home in the evening. It was a deeply emotional experience, made more memorable by my friends and neighbours, who welcomed me to our building by playing the dhol (drums) and letting off firecrackers. Every time I did something worthwhile in my career my friends and neighbours wanted to celebrate the homecoming, and normally I would ask Anjali to persuade them not to because I felt embarrassed by such celebrations – but the World Cup was an exception!

When my mother was performing aarti (a flame ritual for good luck) and putting the tika (vermilion blessing) on my forehead (a family ritual in most Maharashtrian families), it seemed that this time I had come back to her having achieved something substantial. I felt as if I had performed my duties as a son and deserved her welcome. My family was delighted with the achievement and I felt a sense of genuine pride at having given them such joy.